

A LOCH OF GRACE AND GREED

A TALE OF LEVANTHRIA

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CHAPTER I

A LOCH OF GRACE AND GREED

We wait by the foot of the mountains whose peaks stand unseen, bedded in clouds. A harsh frost clings to the sides of the rocks and pale snowdrifts build steadily at the base.

Sitting by a small fire, I press a whetstone against the stained metal of the hatchet that lies across my knees, grinding up to the edge of the blade. The heat from the fire kisses my legs and for the first time in a while, the numbness in my toes begins to leave.

“Care to explain what happened back there?” I recognise the voice of Eacharn Greum, his tone warning me of his displeasure.

I focus on my task and continue to sharpen my axe.

“Do not test me, Leandra.” His gruff voice cuts through the dark, startling me.

I reluctantly raise my head. I might be strong willed, but I am not stupid. Though Eacharn is my uncle, he will still make an example of me if I show disobedience towards him.

“Ostair threatened me, and I gave him reason not to do so again.” I show little emotion in my words. Ostair has had this coming for some time. He is a vile man who has long kept his eyes on me, and too often makes remarks about my form.

“Leandra, the man can barely walk!” Eacharn barks, his thick grey beard shining against the light that the moon offers. His face is weary and worn, and he carries a scar from the top of his nose down to his lower cheekbone. The mass of hair on his face makes up for the lack of hair on his head. “If you continue to strike at everyone who offends you, we will have no one left to protect the village. You need to conduct yourself with more grace.”

“Grace!” I spit, “Would you be saying such words if I were your nephew and not your niece? Uncle, I ask to be treated no differently and I stand by this. How would you respond should someone make eyes at you, or threatening comments?”

“You would be wise to calm your words, Leandra,” Eacharn growls, “I grow impatient with your disobedience.” His chest puffs out and his cheeks become bloated with frustration.

A rush of fire fills my heart and I rise, my hatchet clenched tightly in my hand. “Gron!” I curse, part of me wanting to prove a point, part meaning every word of the insult. Within a second, his curled fist meets my cheek and I find myself flung backwards through the fire. Eacharn grabs me by the scruff of my clothes and raises me to my feet before taking hold of my throat.

As he pulls me closer, I can see the mess in his beard from his food, and the smell of ale lingers on his breath. I grab at his hands as I struggle to breathe. Eacharn is as

powerful as a bear, and as dangerous; his hulking frame is twice the size of my own.

“You are only here because your ma begged me. Do not mistake this as kindness.” Eacharn’s grip around my throat tightens and I am completely at his mercy as my legs flail.

When he does finally loosen his grip, my legs crumble beneath me and I meet the dirt. I plant my hands and gasp for air, coughing and spluttering. I would do it again in an instant just to see the look of anger across my uncle’s face.

Eacharn spits at the ground in front of me, then turns and joins the others who are making idle song as they laugh and joke over ale. How they are meant to defend the village in such a state is beyond me, but our people are renowned for their fierceness on the battlefield as much as our love of ale.

I dust myself down, pick up my hatchet, and begin to press the whetstone against it again. I mutter under my breath all the while, cursing the very men of this village.

An hour passes and I sit staring into the flames, the roaring laughter from the centre of camp dampening to the drunken ramblings of the few men that remain. I hold a small fish embedded into the end of a skewer over my fire, and the smell of the meat cooking gives me hunger pangs. My face still throbs from Eacharn’s strike and my left cheek has swelled, affecting my ability to see properly. The pain pulsates in time with the beating of my heart, and I replay the confrontation with my uncle over and over in my mind. Each time, I think about the different ways I could have reacted to the situation that would have given me an upper hand. I loved a good fight as much as the rest of the warriors in our village but unlike them, I would sit quietly after, and reflect in order to better my reactions the next time.

The snap of a branch snaps me from my deepened thoughts and my gaze is drawn to the darkened trees on the outskirts of camp. There is a reason why we are based here, away from the village. We're not supposed to be fighting each other; we're lying in wait, preparing to face the soldiers that come this way. The southern region of Levanthria has some of the harshest winters in the realm, and our people rarely travel north. Word has spread that the king's forces have moved south to gather supplies and people – including men, women, and children – to fight in a war that he wishes to rage against foreign forces. He is a false king in our eyes. One that we do not acknowledge, he holds no sway over the people of Bragoa. Our camp sits here to head them off, though the men of my village are foolish in their haste to make song and drink, leaving us vulnerable.

There is another snap of a branch and I know that these forces are here. I reach down and take hold of my hatchet.

Men and women scream battle cries as they rush from the darkness towards our camp, and I ready myself for the fight, my chest beating wildly like a drum, adrenaline coursing through me. The soldiers wear the king's colours of yellow and black. They raise their weapons, ready to swarm us.

A scrawny soldier reaches me first, his speed enabled by his slight frame. He takes a wild lunge at me with his sword. I know in an instant he is inexperienced in battle, and I easily duck the attack before slamming my hatchet into his back, the blade crunching through his bones. His blood sprays into me as I spin and slam my hatchet into another soldier's stomach. This first wave of infantrymen wears light armour, making them easier to dispatch. The arrival of the king's soldiers is met with the feral cry of the warriors from our clan. Even ale hasn't prevented them

from responding. If anything, it has made them even more ferocious. Our people are larger; our men stand at between six and seven feet depending on age, and our women reach a height of six feet in adulthood.

The king's soldiers are met by a wall of brutes, and my people begin to bury their warhammers and greataxes into the bodies of our enemies. As I continue to cut through the soldiers with ease, I am grateful for my leather armour, which allows me to move freely whilst offering me some protection. To my right I hear the roars of Eacharn, whose cries of anger drown out the screams of the men he fells like trees. He swings his warhammer like it weighs nothing. I hear the loud crush of bones as he slams it into the chest of a soldier who attempts to run.

“Do not let them get through!” He roars.

Bodies start splaying across the ground and blood drenches the forest floor before being trodden into the dirt, forming a clotted, crimson mud.

Not many of our warriors have fallen and the king's men begin to thin until only a few remain. A woman rushes me, but I strike her face with the wood from my hatchet, knocking her backwards. I quickly flick my axe to my free hand and strike it across her throat, her gargled breaths pointless as she bleeds to death in front of me.

The last of the foot soldiers are taken out in the most brutal of fashion. Limbs are removed and bones are broken until all manner of screams of pain and anguish fade. The bellows of our warriors ring out as they cheer, exclaiming the initial victory. I am not naive enough to believe that this fight is done, and I take my opportunity to gather my breath whilst readying myself for the next wave.

“Brace yourselves, I hear something,” Eacharn roars

loudly, taking charge of his men who are spread out over the makeshift battle camp.

I stand to the left of the field and count around twenty dead men and women around us. Only two of our warriors have fallen, which means we still have over forty in our ranks.

The battle cries of our men stop and for a moment there is silence within the field of dead bodies. I try to focus. I can hear feet making ground at speed and it grows louder as they approach. The next wave arrives on horseback.

They appear in droves through the trees, some with lances, some carrying pikes, some with swords outstretched to strike us down. I am alarmed by the sheer numbers that break through, and a

s the horses reach me, I roll forwards, dodging the pike that was pointed at my chest. I bring myself up and hack the hind leg of the horse and it keels over, catapulting its rider. No sooner does he hit the ground, a hammer is raised above his head and slammed into his chest by Morgrim, Eacharn's second-in-command. His face is barely visible through his long, matted hair and his even darker beard.

I continue forward at a much quicker pace than the more heavily-armoured warriors of our clan, hacking at the horses' legs. I am then greeted by more foot soldiers who emerge from the woods, joining the cavalry. They are swarming us and now their numbers easily outmatch ours.

My hatchet bounces off the large metal shield of one of the foot soldiers as we exchange blows. The king's infantrymen carry better quality armour and weapons than us. This soldier wears chainmail. He strikes me with his free hand but I manage to grab hold of his wrist, preventing his sword from slicing me in half. Our eyes meet with equal rage. Hatred fuels us both and we continue to grapple to get

the upper hand. He is strong but I can see the surprise in his face that his strength is equally matched by a woman. I can feel his arm begin to weaken. Finally, I slam my head into his while letting out a battle cry of my own. He staggers back and loses his footing and I am quickly upon him. I swing my hatchet down, time and time again, until his bloodied face does not resemble that of a human anymore. I pant frantically as I embrace the wildness of my people. Those that attack us will know our fury and will feel our wrath.

A searing pain greets my shoulder and I find myself staring up at the stars above. Raising my hand, I feel the wood that is buried deep in my flesh. Arrows begin to fire towards us. From where I lie, I see our warriors beginning to fall as they are sprayed with the cowardly weapons.

I force myself to sit up and survey the battlefield, ignoring the arrow that maims me. Blood courses out from my shoulder, the injury causing my shoulder to stoop. Our warriors are dropping quickly now and there is no hope that we will win this. There are arrows embedded into Eacharn's body but this does not deter him. He moves forward through those that oppose him as he strikes them down one after the other with every swing of his warhammer. No longer does the forged metal shine with the craftsmanship of our people; it is soaked in the blood of our enemies, of those that wish to take our people by force. As I stand, another bolt hits me in the same shoulder, this one slightly lower. It takes my breath away but I manage to stay myself from falling over. My left side now injured beyond use, I cut down whoever comes close enough with my hatchet.

There are only a few of us still standing now. We continue our fight against an enemy that we have never

wronged, and my hatred for them grows even deeper. Eacharn roars as he takes down three men at once with an almighty swing of his hammer. The gods must be watching down on us with pride.

A man moves toward Eacharn who is almost equal in size. He is heavily armoured and his skin is as dark as the night sky. I have never seen his kind before, but I can tell from his form that he is of elven heritage. Eacharn casts eyes on him and begins his charge.

“Leave him to me,” the man roars at the soldiers who obey without fail, lowering their weapons. This man holds rank over the others, and I pray that Eacharn will best him in combat.

He points his greatsword at Eacharn who reaches him within seconds. The two of them begin trading heavy blows with one another, but my uncle is weakened by the arrows that now decorate his body. Eacharn swipes his hammer at his foe’s head, but he misses, and his momentum swings him past. The elven man swipes his greatsword at Eacharn who lets out a scream as it cuts through his back with ease. He drops to his knees and our eyes meet across the battlefield. Eacharn plants his hammer to the ground to steady himself from falling. The elf stands behind him and raises his sword high, gipping the hilt with both hands, delivering the killing blow. I do not cry for him, I do not shed a tear for his loss of life – I shed tears for the pride I share for my uncle who has fought with honour. He may have always been a brute towards me, however he has fought until the end to protect our clan.

The sword is pressed deeply through the back of his neck, and blood begins to pool in his mouth. At least he has been given an honourable death with his weapon still in his hand.

“Let me avenge my fallen brothers and sisters!” I raise my head to the skies as if I speak to the gods. It is only them that can save me now. “Let me spill the blood of those that are responsible for this!” My words are true but there is no one to hear them. I am surrounded by death. The wailing of my tribe is all I can hear as they are slaughtered on the battlefield.

It is at this moment that a third arrow slams into my chest. I feel no pain as I meet the blood-soaked mud.

I embrace the darkness that awaits me.

I AM BARELY CONSCIOUS, but I can feel the pressure on my leg as I am dragged through the thick, congealed mud. I struggle to open my eyes, my body burning as if I am engulfed in flames. I force my eyes open. My vision is blurry, but I can make out the silhouette of a stooped figure. With surprising strength, she is dragging me across the ground with a rope.

“What are you doing, where are you taking me?” My voice is barely a whisper as I choke on the pooled blood in my mouth, the taste of iron making me want to vomit.

The old hag merely hums a song as if she is singing me a lullaby. I am unable to make out the words that she is muttering, and my consciousness drifts, my head is dizzyed. I am left wondering why I have not already greeted the afterlife.

“What are you doing?” I try once more but the blood in my mouth bubbles. The words I try to form are not the same as the rasping air that leaves my throat. Reaching out in vain, I flail my arms as they flop around limply, like they do not belong to me. I try to grab hold of anything I can, with no success. I think about my uncle who has fallen and

worry about the fate of those left undefended in my village. The sense of hopelessness consumes me. I do not cry easily, yet I feel my eyes pool with tears as my mind transports me to the darkest of places. It does not take much to imagine what those soldiers will be doing to the women and children, all manner of monstrous acts.

I let out a sigh and my arms collapse above me. My strength is gone, and I feel broken, my pain agonising as the old hag continues to drag me through the dense trees.

All the while she continues to hum a melody that I am unfamiliar with. It does not soothe me in the slightest – if anything, it raises my concerns even more.

Where is she taking me?

Even when humming, the crackle in her vocal cords is clear, as if she has spent all her years inhaling smoke. The hag continues steadily, dragging me along, my body grinding against every rock, broken branch, and spiked shrub that we meet.

“Kill me,” I rasp, the blood in my mouth spilling over my face. There is no hope for me now; my wounds are too far gone, the crimson trail I leave behind a sign that my body runs dry. “Please.” This is pain like I have never endured, the most undignified I have ever felt. There would have been honour in dying on the battlefield, but there is no honour in this.

The old hag stops in her tracks. At first I think this is to oblige my request for her to end my life. I take shallow breaths, each one getting harder and harder. My head is throbbing, the world around me pulsating as the light continues to fade into darkness. I know not whether this is because of the falling sun or my loss of consciousness. All I know is I want to be released from this world, from this pain.

“We’re here,” the hag’s voice creaks, like an ancient tree cracking as it bends in the wind. She drops the rope from her shoulder and turns to face me, her features hidden by the shadows.

“What do you want from me?” I am unable to move, my body paralysed from blood loss. I cling to life now, and I know death is not far.

“What do I want, dear?” The old hag seems confused by my question. “I merely respond to your request to the gods.” She grabs hold of my legs and begins to pull me once more. The darkness lifts as we escape the trees, opening up to the light of the moon.

In this instant, I know where she has brought me.

“The loch?” I am bemused as to why I have been dragged from the battlefield to the Loch of Bragoa.

“Why, to heal you, dear.” She casts me a smile, revealing her cracked and broken teeth. “Was it not revenge that you wanted? Against those that have done this to you? To those that have slaughtered your clan like cattle?”

I do not see how I can possibly be healed from these wounds. “Why the loch?” I croak.

I know this loch well. There is no life here – its waters are full of disease and decay, and those that drink from the loch end up sick. My ancestors tried fishing these waters when they first formed our village, but for years we have always avoided this place. I can’t bring my head around why I would be brought here, and I have no idea how this hag intends to heal me.

I feel the rocks scraping against my back as she drags me to the edge of the valley, a sheer drop between myself and the water. The world grows darker. I attempt to roll to my side and relieve the pressure on my lungs, but I have nothing left. My body is a vessel devoid of life.

Beside me, the hag raises her hands to the clouds and begins chanting words that I do not understand. "Septum, Vorah, Krako, Ramora!" Her words echo loudly over the loch, her croaking voice suddenly more assertive, more powerful. "Septum, Vorah, Krako, Ramora!" She bellows once more, with even more conviction. The clouds above begin to separate and swirl as if it is the hag that controls them. Behind them the sky turns a deep purple.

"SEPTUM, VORAH, KRAKO, RAMORA!" She brings her hands over me. At once, I feel as though lightning from the storm clouds strike me and my body begins to burn with intensity as if I have been thrown into a volcano. My jaw clenches tightly as my body begins to convulse violently. I bite down involuntarily, hard enough that I feel my teeth shatter. I have no idea what witchcraft the hag is using but it is something I do not welcome. The agonising pain I was feeling as I was dragged here is replaced by something much worse.

My body continues to shake, and through the hag's chants I hear a crack. I scream out in pain as the bones in my legs shatter. Blood sprays from my mouth as more bones break, starting at my ankles and slowly making way up my legs to my thighs. It stops for a moment, the thunderous clouds subsiding as if the storm the hag summoned has passed. I am gasping now, and it feels as though the air is becoming thicker than the blood that I am drowning in. In this moment I pray for death, for the pain to stop, for all of this to be over. Then another crack echoes over the loch. This time it is my ribs breaking, and I scream with heightened agony.

I try to ask the hag why she is doing this, but no words leave my mouth. My throat feels as if it has been sealed shut, and I begin to pass out.

The hag casts one final look over my broken body, her cracked skin and deep wrinkles examining me like an artist would a painting. "You will survive this dear. The gods have allowed it. But not without a price. These tainted waters are where you will live. The waters that poison everything else are what will keep you alive. Your years will far stretch beyond that of mortal men. You will have the revenge that you seek." The hag places her foot on my side, and I feel that where my ribs should be is now soft, as if my bones have completely disintegrated.

"YOU WILL WALK the land every five years. It is in these moments you will have your revenge, it is in these moments you will paint the mountains with the blood of those that have done this to you." She pushes her foot against me and I feel weightless as I plummet down the side of the rock face.

Slamming against the loch, I hear my skin sizzle like water being cast onto a fire. The black waters are freezing but soothe me almost immediately. The harrowing pain begins to subside, the sharpness of the cold jolting my eyes open. Suddenly I feel very much conscious and aware of my surroundings. I feel myself sink down into the depths, and I find myself able to see, despite the darkness. I can make out the rock formations that surround me. A newfound energy strengthens my limbs and I wave my arms to try and prevent myself plummeting even deeper, holding my breath. I attempt to kick my legs to slow my descent, but something doesn't feel right; they move as one, as if my bones have been fused together. I kick in a wild panic. Searching below for the source of my entrapment, my eyes widen at what I see: my legs are no longer there. They have

been replaced with what looks like the scales you would see on a sea creature. I scream but the sound is muffled, and only bubbles escape my mouth. I kick again, desperate to reach the water's surface. I find myself moving through the waters quicker than I could have before tonight. A tight knot forms in my stomach as I struggle to hold my breath any longer. I'm going to drown. I flick my tail and thrash, but it is too late. Against my wishes, my body tries to take in air, and I gasp.

A strange sensation runs through my ribs as if water passes through them. A moment later, the tight knot in my stomach disappears and I find myself breathing freely. The water is pulled inside me through my ribs, and it feels exhilarating. The coldness seems to heal my broken bones, giving me the feeling of new life. I sit motionless in the water, taking in breath after breath, each one revitalising my body. My panic having subsided, I now stare out at the vast landscape around me.

This is my new home.

Tethered to a new body, I am cursed to live in these waters. It is a curse that I embrace and I am grateful to the gods. Five years I must wait, according to the hag. However miserable my life might be down here, it will be worth it for the blood that I will spill in revenge for the attack on my village. The king and his armies will pay for the slaughter of my people.

I am Leandra Frostworn, and I will have my vengeance.

"SHE MOVED through the battlefield with the grace of a goddess, her blades dispensed upon any man or woman who stood in her way. Let it be put to the records that it was the greed of the king that created this monster. That it was

he who unleashed this daemonic creature into this world. The creature who now stalks the land making her fury known every five years. The Beast of Bragoa”

-The Legends of Bragoa: Jordell Torvin, alchemist and bookkeeper of the great Temple of Askela. 256KR

AFTERWORD

I hope you enjoyed this short story set in the world of Levanthria. This dark fantasy retelling series has grown into something far bigger than I ever imagined. Each story is a fantasy retelling inspired by British folklore legends, from Robin Hood, Blackbeard, The Pendle Witches and St George.

If you did enjoy it be sure to check out the other books in the series, if you have joined my newsletter you will receive all information on upcoming books in the series.

I look forward to sharing more stories with you.

A.P Beswick

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